Family Business

By Simon Rich

NARRATOR: I love my father, but sometimes he can get on my nerves. It's hard to explain why exactly. It's just little things he does, here and there, that bother me. For example, sometimes he *poops* into his hands and then throws it into my face while jumping up and down and screaming. I know he's just trying to be funny. But I've asked him politely not to do it anymore, but I always get the same reaction.

FATHER: *(rolling his eyes)* I'm sorry, your majesty.

INTRODUCTION

For most of history, what we did for a living was decided for us by our families. We would either join the family business or accept their suggestions for what we might do. On the surface, most families claim to have no interest in their children doing any job in particular. They simply "want us to be happy." Or do they?

Welcome to the Jungle . . . where this set of chimpanzee parents have more than a little trouble accepting their child's career choice.

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NARRATOR: My father's been calling me "your majesty" for as long as I can remember. He does it whenever I rinse off fruit before eating it or catch grubs with a stick instead of my fingers. Basically, he does it whenever I do anything differently than he does. When I told him I was thinking about going to school, he didn't even respond. He just kept picking dirt out of his belly button. *(to father)* There's a human scientist interviewing chimpanzees to see if any have the aptitude to learn sign language.

FATHER: *(laughing)* And you think they're going to pick you. I'd like to see ***that***.

MOTHER: Why can't you just stay here? There are plenty of job opportunities. I talked to your Uncle Mike and he said he'd help you find work at the *poop* pile.

FATHER: It's good, honest work. Decent pay, great benefits. You think you're too ***good*** for it?

NARRATOR: No! Dad, relax. I'm just interested in sign language. I think it would be a cool thing to study.

FATHER: *(snorting)* So you get into this fancy program and spend years learning sign language. What are you supposed to do with that afterward? Teach?

MOTHER: You know, your father was pretty big in the human world when he was young. *(nudging him)* Tell him about the time you met you-know-who.

FATHER: So, this one time, I'm hanging out in my nest, when Jane pops over—"

MOTHER: *(whispering)* He means Jane Goodall.

FATHER: *(grinning, with bravado)* So Jane opens her banana crate, and she says to me, 'How about a banana?' And so *I* say, 'How about ***many*** bananas?

MOTHER: *(laughs hysterically)*

NARRATOR: *(grimacing, to audience)* My father's been telling us his Goodall anecdote for years. What does that even mean? Many bananas? That's not even a joke. *(to father)* Where did you say you met Jane Goodall?

FATHER: *(cautiously)* My nest.

NARRATOR: So, on top of a tree? That's pretty interesting. Because the trees we nest in are very tall. And humans usually aren't that great at climbing. She must have been pretty ***athletic*** to make it all the way up to your nest. And to carry a crate with her, no less, one that was filled with, as you say, many bananas—that's ***really*** impressive.

FATHER: *(tensely with flared nostrils)* I don't know what to tell you. That's how it happened.

NARRATOR: I always knew your friend Jane was smart, but I had no idea she was also the strongest human in the history of— *(a clump of poop lands on his/her face. Coughing and sputtering, while wiping it away).*

MOTHER: *(ready to launch another clump)* Don't you ***ever*** disrespect your father like that again. *(she stares angrily then gallops off screaming)*

******* The Next Day *******

NARRATOR: I met with the scientists.

FITZBAUM: Here, chimpy, chimpy. Who wants to win a banana?

NARRATOR: They said I was the smartest chimp they'd ever seen.

FATHER: *(he and mother are grooming each other, disinterested)* La di da. Good for you.

MOTHER: It was a big day at the *poop* pile. *(proudly)* Your father found three grubs.

FATHER: The trick is to feel around in the *poop*. The grubs are sometimes at the bottom, so you need to reach down. *(demonstrating)*

MOTHER: You're so smart. The smartest, most wonderful—

NARRATOR: *(interrupting)* I'm flying to Stanford tomorrow. It's in a human country called the U.S.A.

MOTHER: *(fearfully)* A *human country*? Like Zimbabwe?

NARRATOR: Yeah, but bigger.

FATHER: *(snorting)* Bigger than Zimbabwe? Not likely. How come I've never heard of it?

MOTHER: *(whimpers)*

NARRATOR: Mom, come on. Don't whimper. This is my chance to get out of this town. To see the world.

FATHER: *(suddenly angry, he roars)* Then ***go!*** Go have fun with your fancy human friends! *(baring his teeth in a grimacing smile)* Just don't come crawling back to me when you fail.

*******5 Years Later at the White House*********

FIRST LADY: *(to a large audience, she speaks into a microphone)* Ladies and gentlemen. In honor of Earth Day, we have a very special speaker. Please 'go ape' for . . . Professor Chimpsky!

NARRATOR: *(signing – left paw to lips)* Thank you. Thank you. Thank you. Thank you. (to audience) There were dozens of cameras trained on me, broadcasting my speech all over the world. I was determined to do my species proud. *(Signing and speaking aloud- See NOTE at end of selection for ASL resource link)* Environment good. Peace. Earth Day. Hello. Peace. Me chimpanzee. Peace. Thank you. Goodbye. *(to audience)* The crowd burst into applause. The speech had been an enormous success—far greater than I had even hoped. It was the pinnacle of my entire career. Still, as usual, I had trouble enjoying my triumph. *(sadly)* I hadn't had any contact with my parents since the day I left the jungle. Part of me

wished they could see how far I'd come. In just five years, I'd amassed more accolades than any chimp in history. My mastery of sign language was so vast and fluent that it had earned Professor Fitzbaum a MacArthur "genius" grant. My face had appeared in every magazine on earth.

A caterer set down a tray of champagne flutes. Fitzbaum was busy talking to some reporters. I grabbed two flutes. I was starting to feel a bit light-headed, but I didn't care. I was almost finished with my champagne when Professor Fitzbaum returned.

FITZBAUM: *(signing and speaking)* Stop. No. Give *(pointing to the champagne)* ***Give***.

NARRATOR: A crowd had formed. There were dignitaries, reporters, and—most troubling of all—a man holding a dart gun. *(stamping his feet and pounding his chest – he roars)* Everyone was overreacting. I jumped onto a table and collided with a large ice sculpture of a globe. I don't remember much after that. Just the sound of shouting, the smell of grass, and a sharp little pain in my thigh. *(beat, then with shame)* I woke up in a cage. I was starting to despair when Professor Fitzbaum walked into the room. *(to Fitzbaum signing frantically and speaking)* Hello! Hello! *(to audience)* My friend had come to get me, just like I'd known he would. *(signing again)* Thank you. Hello. Me chimpanzee. Good. Please. Friends. *(clinging to the bars of the cage)*

FITZBAUM: *(no signing, he is resigned)* I'm sorry, but our facilities can't accommodate a full-grown chimpanzee. *(Narrator begins to sob)* Don't worry, you don't have to stay here. I'm taking you home.

******* Back in the Jungle*******

FATHER: Guess it didn't work out, huh? Well, don't say I didn't warn you.

MOTHER: It's O.K. I've already talked to Uncle Mike, and there's a place for you at the *poop* pile. *(she hands him a few grubs, which he tries to eat, but they are disgusting now. Makes a horrible face)*

FATHER: *(with his mouth full of grubs)* What's the matter? Not fancy enough for you?

NARRATOR: Dad. I just got back. Please . . . *(unconsciously signing the last word)*

FATHER: *(gasping)* What the hell are you doing?

NARRATOR: It's sign language. Look, I'll show you. *(to audience)* I tried to teach them "Thank you" the easiest sign I knew. *(paw to lips)*

FATHER: *(laughing)* I can't believe you spent five years on that nonsense. What a waste.

NARRATOR: *(defiantly)* It wasn't a waste. I got to do all sorts of amazing things— I got to go to the White House.

FATHER: *(unimpressed)* What's that?

NARRATOR: It's where the President of the United States lives. *(Father snorts)*

MOTHER: You know, your ***father*** once met a celebrity. Honey, tell him about the time you talked to you-know-who.

FATHER: Oh, all right. So, one time, I'm in my tree, and Jane—

MOTHER: He means Jane Goodall. *(aside – she whispers to Narrator sadly)* He's old! Can't you see he's *old?*

NARRATOR: *(rolling his eyes, but then realizing that Father is indeed quite old and sad)* I love my father (to Father) Dad, I'm hungry. I never ate dinner. I wish there were grubs I could eat. *(poking at the ground and feigning confusion)* I'm not good at it. I need help from an expert—someone who knows about grubs and about *poop*

FATHER: *(with renewed swagger)* I can help. The trick is to really get in there with your paws. See? *(pulls out a grub and hands it to Narrator)*

NARRATOR: *(forced smile)* Thanks. *(shoves the grub into his/her mouth)* Mmm. Delicious. You're good at hunting grubs. I'm really impressed.

FATHER: *(beating his chest he roars triumphantly)*

FOR

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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NOTE: Words the Narrator signs can be found here
American Sign Language Dictionary ***https://www.signasl.org/***
Search and compare thousands of words and phrases in American Sign Language (ASL). The largest collection of video signs online.

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